



Archer Aviation

NYSE : ACHR · Young-
Company DCF
(Damodaran)

\$4.17B mkt cap · 790M sh · \$1.78B cash, \$80M debt · \$1.78B cash (\$0.95B + \$0.83B ST inv), low debt; ~760M basic / ~790M diluted; Pre-revenue (Q1'26 first \$1.6M); ~\$727M/yr burn, ~2.4yr runway; Anduril defense JV + \$142M USAF; ~\$6B order book (mostly LOIs)

22 July 2026 · the qualitative

\$5.28

Is Archer's ~half-Joby price enough discount to make the eVTOL-plus-defense lottery ticket positive-EV — despite being the certification follower?

Archer trades at ~\$5.4B (~\$6.81/sh) on \$0 revenue — about half Joby's cap on a near-identical certification position, with \$1.78B cash but a ~\$727M/yr burn (~2.4yr runway) and a defense wildcard (the Anduril autonomous-VTOL JV) Joby lacks. The young-company DCF asks what aircraft fleet, UAM-plus-defense revenue, and dilution are plausible over a decade. The finding: 85% of the probability sits well below spot — heavy dilution craters the bear/base outcomes — but Archer is cheap enough that the 15% cert-success-plus-defense tail (paying 4-13x) lifts the weighted expected modestly above today's price.

\$8.01

expected fair value today
+51.8% vs spot \$5.28

+5y	+10y	+15y	+20y
\$11.48	\$16.47	\$23.64	\$33.99
2.17× spot	3.12× spot	4.48× spot	6.44× spot

Ultra Bear 12% TC fails (Lilium-style); cash burns; near-total loss.

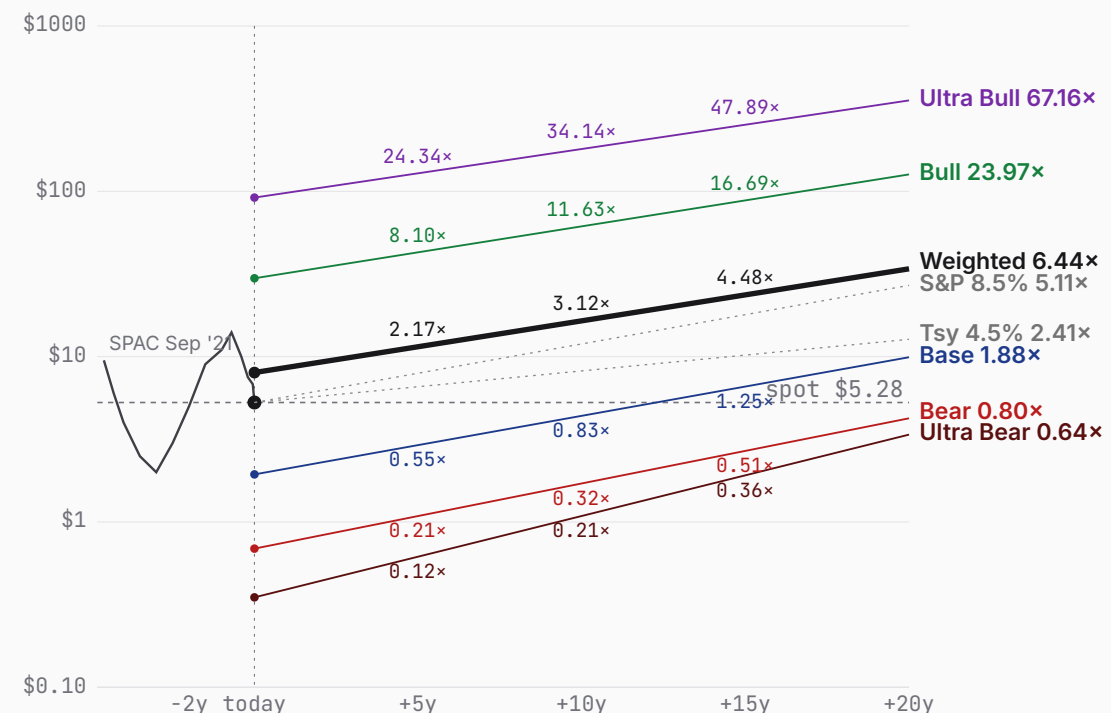
Bear 31% Cert slips; lean sub-scale operator; dilution wins.

Base 42% Cert ~2027: mid-scale UAM + defense: diluted.

Bull 11% Cert + DoD program of record; ~5x spot.

Ultra Bull 4% UAM leader + major defense program; ~14x.

Bull (11%) + Ultra Bull (4%) together contribute \$6.94 — 87% of the \$8.01 expected value despite 15% combined probability. Today's spot (\$5.28) sits 34% below the weighted expected; forward-weighted value crosses spot between +5y and +10y.



ULTRA BEAR	\$0.35	BEAR	\$0.69	BASE	\$1.94	BULL	\$29.79	ULTRA BULL	\$91.64
	-93.4% vs spot		-86.9% vs spot		-63.3% vs spot		+464.2% vs spot		+1635.6% vs spot
TAM 0.0% P(fail) 45% S2C 0.6 Prob 12%		TAM 0.5% P(fail) 35% S2C 1.0 Prob 31%		TAM 2.2% P(fail) 18% S2C 1.2 Prob 42%		TAM 6.4% P(fail) 8% S2C 1.5 Prob 11%		TAM 9.6% P(fail) 4% S2C 1.7 Prob 4%	
TC fails (Lilium-style); cash burns; dilution.		Cert slips; lean sub-scale operator.		Cert ~2027; UAM scales + defense kicker.		Cert + DoD program of record win.		UAM leader + major defense program.	



Archer Aviation scenario narratives

PROBABILITY WEIGHTS

Ultra Bear 12% Bear 31% Base 42% Bull 11% Ultra Bull 4% · Weighted expected \$8.01 (+51.8% vs spot)

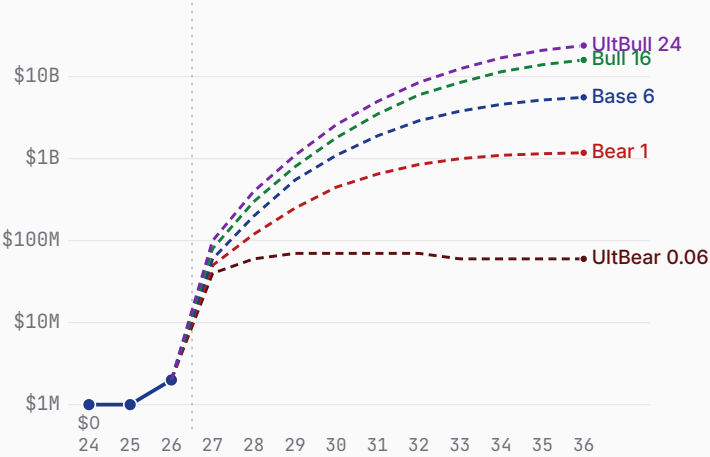
ULTRA BEAR	\$0.35	BEAR	\$0.69	BASE	\$1.94	BULL	\$29.79	ULTRA BULL	\$91.64
	-93.4% vs spot		-86.9% vs spot		-63.3% vs spot		+464.2% vs spot		+1635.6% vs spot
Probability 12%		Probability 31%		Probability 42%		Probability 11%		Probability 4%	
TC fails (Lilium-style); cash burns; dilution.		Cert slips; lean sub-scale operator.		Cert ~2027; UAM scales + defense kicker.		Cert + DoD program of record win.		UAM leader + major defense program.	
WHY 12%		WHY 31%		WHY 42%		WHY 11%		WHY 4%	
The category's base rate is unforgiving — no one holds an FAA Type Certificate yet, and Lilium (raised \$1.4B, failed) proves under-capitalization is fatal. Archer is the cert-follower with ≈2.4yr of runway; 45% within-scenario failure reflects real first-of-a-kind certification + funding risk. 12% scenario weight.		Cert slips and the business stays sub-scale; the ~\$6B order book (mostly LOIs) converts only partially. 35% failure probability — Archer is behind Joby on conforming-aircraft flight testing. 31% weight as a very plausible 'certifies but the dilution wins' outcome.		Requires cert on roughly schedule and a mid-scale UAM-plus-defense ramp — no category dominance. 18% failure probability given \$1.78B cash, Stellantis manufacturing, and the USAF/Anduril defense anchor. 42% weight as the central outcome.		A chain: cert clears AND manufacturing ramps AND UAM scales AND the Anduril relationship becomes a DoD program of record. Each plausible at 50-70%; jointly ~11%. The defense leg is Archer's distinctive second shot at the upside.		Tail of tails: UAM leadership AND a major multi-service defense program AND a premium platform terminal. Individually 40-60%; jointly ~4%. The asymmetric upside that the half-Joby price is really buying.	
WHAT HAPPENS		WHAT HAPPENS		WHAT HAPPENS		WHAT HAPPENS		WHAT HAPPENS	
Type certification defeats Archer — a flight-test setback, a transition-flight failure, or simply running out of runway (≈2.4yr of cash at the ~\$727M/yr burn) before the FAA grants a TC. Lilium's 2025 collapse proves the category kills the under-capitalized. Archer dilutes desperately at collapsing prices, then restructures; the residual is defense scraps plus whatever cash survives the attempt.		Archer eventually certifies but late and sub-scale; it becomes a lean niche eVTOL operator (~\$1.2B revenue by the mid-2030s at a low-teens margin) plus a modest defense line, never converting the ~\$6B order book or matching Joby's cadence. Heavy dilution (≈\$2.4B of raises at depressed prices) funds the long road to cert.		The modal path: Archer certifies on roughly the targeted timeline (~2027), scales the Midnight UAM network across the US and UAE, and converts part of the Anduril defense relationship into recurring revenue — ~\$5.6B combined by 2035 at a low-teens operating margin. A real, profitable transport-tech business.		The bull: Archer certifies, the Covington/Stellantis line ramps toward high volume, the UAM network scales across multiple metros, AND the Anduril partnership converts into a DoD program of record — ~\$16B combined revenue by 2035 at a ~28% operating margin. The defense leg is the differentiator Joby lacks.		The tail: Archer becomes a US UAM leader AND lands a major multi-service defense program — the autonomous hybrid-VTOL scales into a real DoD platform — for ~\$24B combined revenue by 2035 at a ~34% operating margin and a premium platform terminal.	
With a 45% within-scenario failure probability and the share count ballooning past 1.4B on sub-\$4 raises, the expected per-share collapses toward the distress floor — a near-total loss from today's \$6.81.		The DCF lands under \$1/share — the market is pricing a far larger outcome. This is the 'cert works, but the dilution math wins' world that Joby's bear shares.		But ~\$3.4B of dilutive raises to fund the buildout balloon the share count past 1.2B, and most of the fleet's value sits beyond the 10-year window. DCF ~\$2.25/share — ~67% below spot, the dilution tax on a successful-but-capital-hungry ramp.		Self-funding arrives mid-decade; dilution turns value-accretive. DCF ~\$32/share — ~5× today's price. This is the scenario the cheap entry is really buying.		DCF ~\$95/share — ~14× spot. A genuine 'eVTOL + defense prime' outcome; each leg is individually plausible at 40-60%, jointly ~4%. The asymmetric upside that makes the cheap entry positive-EV.	

Archer Aviation business snapshot

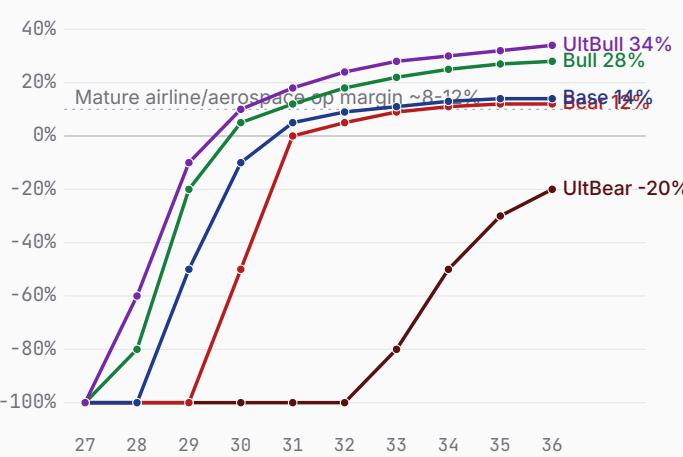
Bear \$0.69 Base \$1.94 Bull \$29.79

FY26-FY35 scenario projections (pre-revenue today) · fiscal years end Dec 31 · Q1 2026 10-Q, FY25 results

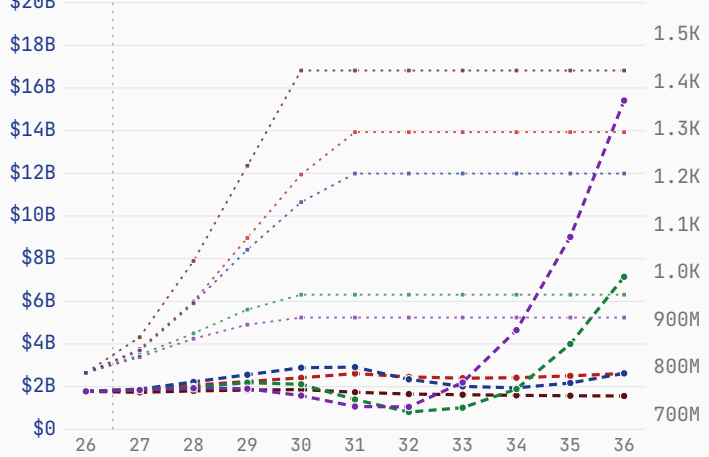
Revenue — history + scenarios to FY36 (log)



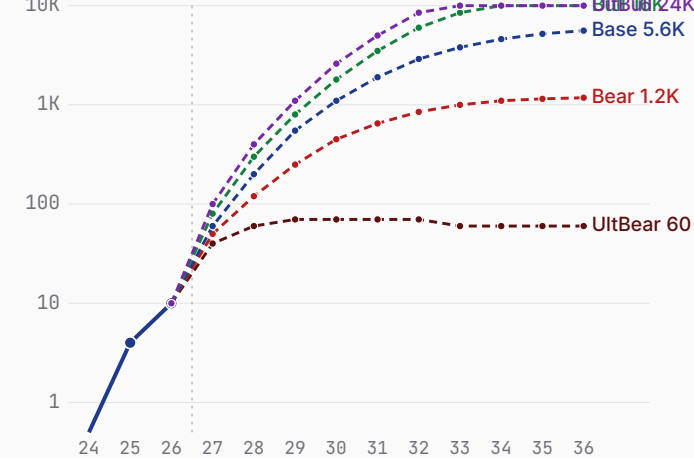
Path to profitability — op margin (FY27→FY36)



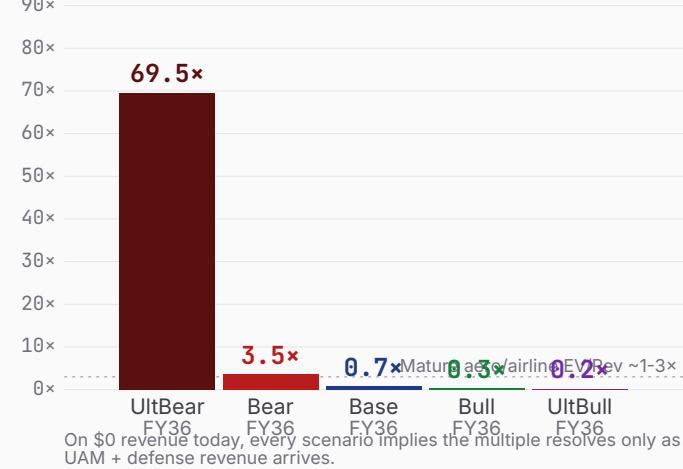
Cash + dilution (FY26 → FY36)



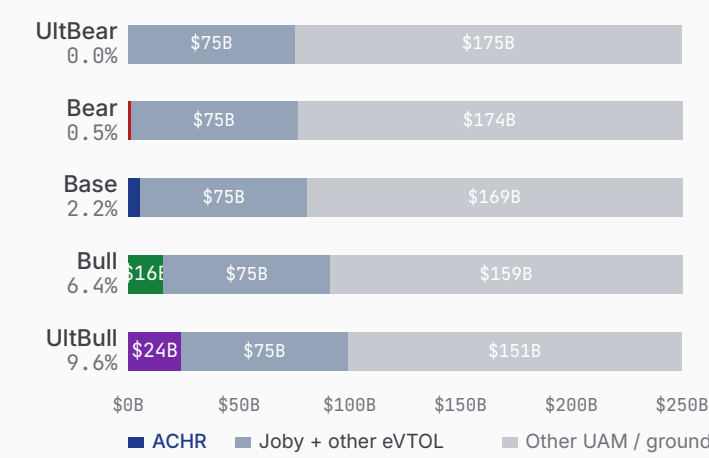
Aircraft fleet deployed (log)



\$4.17B mkt cap as P/S on FY36 rev



\$250B FY36 global UAM TAM — ACHR share (+ separate defense leg)



Sources: Archer Q1 2026 10-Q (cash+ST inv \$1.78B, net loss), FY2025 results (net loss \$618M), order-book + Anduril/USAF disclosures. Revenue modeled as UAM (passenger) + defense; FCF is NOL-shielded pre-tax over the explicit window (documented simplification). TAM: \$250B FY36 global UAM (matches the Joby memo) plus a separate defense leg.

Archer Aviation 7 Powers · the moat, scored

Bear \$0.69 Base \$1.94 Bull \$29.79

Arena. Electric vertical-takeoff air mobility (eVTOL) + defense VTOL — Archer (Midnight UAM 'airline' + Anduril defense) vs Joby (cert + cash leader), Beta, Vertical, EHang (China), Wisk/Boeing (autonomy); the race to originate the first certified, scaled UAM + dual-use position.

POWER ORIENTATION
origination window: open

POWER ORIENTATION · 7 POWERS

Scale Economies	The Covington/Stellantis line targets high volume, but it's pre-cert and unproven at rate.
Network Economies	A vertiport/route-network flywheel is future, not yet originated.
Counter-Positioning	Archer's defense dual-use (Anduril) is a position Joby and pure-UAM peers can't easily mirror.
Switching Costs	Airline/operator + defense-program lock-in is real once contracted, but contracts are early/conditional.
Branding	A leading eVTOL brand (United, Stellantis, Anduril, UAE); strong but unproven on delivery.
Cornered Resource · thesis leans here	An FAA TC (once granted) is the first-mover regulatory moat; Archer is a close #2 with manufacturing + defense assets.
Process Power	No certified aircraft yet; the manufacturing learning curve is ahead, not demonstrated.

THE RACE · NAMED RIVALS

Joby Aviation	Toyota; ~\$2.5B cash
~20% terminal share · Cert + cash leader (Toyota ~\$894M, ~\$2.5B cash, Dubai 6yr exclusive); flew FAA-conforming aircraft for TIA.	
Beta Technologies	>\$1B; QIA, GE
~12% terminal share · eCTOL flying/delivering; eVTOL behind; strong balance sheet (Nov'25 IPO ~\$7.4B); cargo + military.	
Vertical Aerospace	~\$180M; Mudrick
~6% terminal share · VX4; targets cert end-2026; chronically thin balance sheet.	
EHang	China; ~\$97M
~10% terminal share · EH216-S autonomous; CERTIFIED in China (tourism) — but jurisdiction-bound.	
Wisk (Boeing)	Boeing \$450M+
~10% terminal share · Autonomous (no pilot) Gen 6; harder/longer cert, later EIS; Boeing-funded.	

LEAD / LAG · FALSIFIERS

FAA certification stage	closed 'Phase 3'; for-credit testing vs Joby (TIA, conforming a/c flown)	LAGGING
Defense / dual-use	Anduril JV + \$142M USAF vs Joby (limited DoD)	LEADING
Liquidity / runway	\$1.78B (~2.4yr) vs Joby ~\$2.5B	LAGGING

COMPETITIVE READ

Archer is originating a credible #2 eVTOL position plus a distinctive defense dual-use leg (Anduril) that Joby lacks — at roughly half Joby's market cap. But it lags Joby on the one Power that matters first (FAA certification — Joby has flown conforming aircraft for TIA; Archer hasn't), and on cash/runway; the category just killed the under-capitalized Lilium. The window is open as the close #2 with a defense call option, but certification and the ~\$727M/yr burn are the falsifiers the whole bull case must clear.

Archer Aviation show your work

Bear \$0.69 Base \$1.94 Bull \$29.79 · Weighted \$8.01 (+51.8%)

ULTRA BEAR

\$0.35

BEAR

\$0.69

BASE

\$1.94

BULL

\$29.79

ULTRA BULL

\$91.64

ASSUMPTIONS

TAM Year-10 (\$B)	250
Mature share (%)	0.0
Mature op margin (%)	-20
Sales-to-capital	0.6
Terminal WACC (%)	12.0
Terminal growth (%)	2.0
P(failure) (%)	45
Scenario probability (%)	12

10-YEAR DCF · \$B

FY	Rev	Margin	FCF	PV FCF
FY27	0.04	-700%	-0.35	-0.30
FY28	0.06	-500%	-0.33	-0.25
FY29	0.07	-350%	-0.26	-0.17
FY30	0.07	-250%	-0.17	-0.10
FY31	0.07	-180%	-0.13	-0.06
FY32	0.07	-120%	-0.08	-0.04
FY33	0.06	-80%	-0.03	-0.01
FY34	0.06	-50%	-0.03	-0.01
FY35	0.06	-30%	-0.02	-0.01
FY36	0.06	-20%	-0.01	-0.00

Σ PV explicit FCF -0.94

+ PV terminal (g 2.0%) -0.03

EQUITY BUILD · \$B & PER SHARE

Operating EV	\$-0.97B
+ Cash & investments	\$1.78B
= Equity value	\$0.73B
Raised over period	\$1.20B
Dilution by FY36	+80%
FY36 shares (M)	1,425

DCF per share	\$0.51
× (1-P_fail) [55%]	\$0.28
+ P_fail × distress [45% × \$0.15]	\$0.07

= Expected per share \$0.35

FUTURE FAIR VALUE · IF SCENARIO PLAYS OUT

+5y	+10y	+15y	+20y
\$0.62	\$1.09	\$1.92	\$3.38
0.12×	0.21×	0.36×	0.64×

ASSUMPTIONS

TAM Year-10 (\$B)	250
Mature share (%)	0.5
Mature op margin (%)	12
Sales-to-capital	1.0
Terminal WACC (%)	9.5
Terminal growth (%)	2.0
P(failure) (%)	35
Scenario probability (%)	31

10-YEAR DCF · \$B

FY	Rev	Margin	FCF	PV FCF
FY27	0.05	-300%	-0.20	-0.17
FY28	0.12	-200%	-0.31	-0.24
FY29	0.25	-120%	-0.43	-0.29
FY30	0.45	-50%	-0.42	-0.26
FY31	0.65	+0%	-0.20	-0.11
FY32	0.85	+5%	-0.16	-0.08
FY33	1.00	+9%	-0.06	-0.03
FY34	1.10	+11%	+0.02	+0.01
FY35	1.15	+12%	+0.09	+0.03
FY36	1.18	+12%	+0.11	+0.04

Σ PV explicit FCF -1.10

+ PV terminal (g 2.0%) 0.50

EQUITY BUILD · \$B & PER SHARE

Operating EV	\$-0.60B
+ Cash & investments	\$1.78B
= Equity value	\$1.10B
Raised over period	\$2.40B
Dilution by FY36	+64%
FY36 shares (M)	1,296

DCF per share	\$0.85
× (1-P_fail) [65%]	\$0.55
+ P_fail × distress [35% × \$0.40]	\$0.14

= Expected per share \$0.69

FUTURE FAIR VALUE · IF SCENARIO PLAYS OUT

+5y	+10y	+15y	+20y
\$1.09	\$1.71	\$2.69	\$4.24
0.21×	0.32×	0.51×	0.80×

ASSUMPTIONS

TAM Year-10 (\$B)	250
Mature share (%)	2.2
Mature op margin (%)	14
Sales-to-capital	1.2
Terminal WACC (%)	8.5
Terminal growth (%)	2.5
P(failure) (%)	18
Scenario probability (%)	42

10-YEAR DCF · \$B

FY	Rev	Margin	FCF	PV FCF
FY27	0.06	-250%	-0.20	-0.18
FY28	0.20	-120%	-0.36	-0.28
FY29	0.55	-50%	-0.57	-0.40
FY30	1.10	-10%	-0.57	-0.36
FY31	1.90	+5%	-0.57	-0.33
FY32	2.90	+9%	-0.57	-0.29
FY33	3.80	+11%	-0.33	-0.15
FY34	4.60	+13%	-0.07	-0.03
FY35	5.20	+14%	+0.23	+0.09
FY36	5.60	+14%	+0.45	+0.16

Σ PV explicit FCF -1.76

+ PV terminal (g 2.5%) 2.78

EQUITY BUILD · \$B & PER SHARE

Operating EV	\$1.02B
+ Cash & investments	\$1.78B
= Equity value	\$2.72B
Raised over period	\$3.40B
Dilution by FY36	+53%
FY36 shares (M)	1,209

DCF per share	\$2.25
× (1-P_fail) [82%]	\$1.85
+ P_fail × distress [18% × \$0.50]	\$0.09

= Expected per share \$1.94

FUTURE FAIR VALUE · IF SCENARIO PLAYS OUT

+5y	+10y	+15y	+20y
\$2.92	\$4.39	\$6.60	\$9.92
0.55×	0.83×	1.25×	1.88×

ASSUMPTIONS

TAM Year-10 (\$B)	250
Mature share (%)	6.4
Mature op margin (%)	28
Sales-to-capital	1.5
Terminal WACC (%)	7.5
Terminal growth (%)	3.0
P(failure) (%)	8
Scenario probability (%)	11

10-YEAR DCF · \$B

FY	Rev	Margin	FCF	PV FCF
FY27	0.08	-200%	-0.21	-0.19
FY28	0.30	-80%	-0.39	-0.31
FY29	0.80	-20%	-0.49	-0.36
FY30	1.80	+5%	-0.58	-0.38
FY31	3.50	+12%	-0.71	-0.42
FY32	6.00	+18%	-0.59	-0.32
FY33	8.50	+22%	+0.20	+0.10
FY34	11.50	+25%	+0.88	+0.40
FY35	14.00	+27%	+2.11	+0.90
FY36	16.00	+28%	+3.15	+1.24

Σ PV explicit FCF +0.67

+ PV terminal (g 3.0%) 28.43

EQUITY BUILD · \$B & PER SHARE

Operating EV	\$29.10B
+ Cash & investments	\$1.78B
= Equity value	\$30.80B
Raised over period	\$2.00B
Dilution by FY36	+21%
FY36 shares (M)	954

DCF per share	\$32.29
× (1-P_fail) [92%]	\$29.71
+ P_fail × distress [8% × \$1.00]	\$0.08

= Expected per share \$29.79

FUTURE FAIR VALUE · IF SCENARIO PLAYS OUT

+5y	+10y	+15y	+20y
\$42.77	\$61.40	\$88.14	\$126.54
8.10×	11.63×	16.69×	23.97×

ASSUMPTIONS

TAM Year-10 (\$B)	250
Mature share (%)	9.6
Mature op margin (%)	34
Sales-to-capital	1.7
Terminal WACC (%)	7.0
Terminal growth (%)	3.5
P(failure) (%)	4
Scenario probability (%)	4

10-YEAR DCF · \$B

FY	Rev	Margin	FCF	PV FCF
FY27	0.10	-180%	-0.24	-0.21
FY28	0.40	-60%	-0.42	-0.34
FY29	1.10	-10%	-0.52	-0.39
FY30	2.60	+10%	-0.62	-0.42
FY31	5.00	+18%	-0.51	-0.32
FY32	8.50	+24%	-0.02	-0.01
FY33	12.50	+28%	+1.15	+0.60
FY34	17.00	+30%	+2.45	+1.19
FY35	21.00	+32%	+4.37	+1.98
FY36	24.00	+34%	+6.39	+2.70

Σ PV explicit FCF +4.79

+ PV terminal (g 3.5%) 79.94

EQUITY BUILD · \$B & PER SHARE

Operating EV	\$84.73B
+ Cash & investments	\$1.78B
= Equity value	\$86.43B
Raised over period	\$1.60B
Dilution by FY36	+15%
FY36 shares (M)	906

DCF per share	\$95.40
× (1-P_fail) [96%]	\$91.58
+ P_fail × distress [4% × \$1.50]	\$0.06

= Expected per share \$91.64

FUTURE FAIR VALUE · IF SCENARIO PLAYS OUT

+5y	+10y	+15y	+20y
\$128.53	\$180.27	\$252.84	\$354.62
24.34×	34.14×	47.89×	67.16×

Archer Aviation

People · Opportunity · Context · Deal

Bear \$0.69 Base \$1.94 Bull \$29.79

Underwrite the position the way a venture investor underwrites a round — across all four legs, public or private. **People** is the leg scored here (observable only); Opportunity, Context and Deal cross-reference the rest of the memo.

PEOPLE · WHO RUNS / OWNS / FUNDS IT

Adam Goldstein · founder-led

8 yrs in seat

5.55%

insider ownership

HIGH

key-person risk

Capital allocation (realized)
Co-founder Adam Goldstein (founded Archer 2018; sole CEO since April 2022, Chair & CEO since the 2021 listing) runs a pre-revenue eVTOL developer. Capital is going into certification and manufacturing: a large cash balance (~\$1B+, strategic-backed), heavy ATM and strategic raises (the dilution cost), a Stellantis manufacturing partnership plus equity, and United Airlines orders. ~\$727M/yr burn; no dividend or buyback.

Incentive alignment
Founder-led with alignment now matching economics: Goldstein holds ~4.9% and the director/officer group ~5.55% (March 2026). Because the super-voting Class B sunset at the end of 2024, his voting power now equals his economic stake — the former ~37% founder voting control has lapsed.

GOVERNANCE FLAGS

- single class, one vote per share since December 31, 2024 — the former Class B (10-vote) super-voting auto-converted when it fell below the 10% threshold (a governance improvement)
- combined Chair & CEO (Goldstein holds both)
- classified / staggered board (three classes), 7 directors, with a lead independent director (Diaz) and independent Audit/Comp/Nominating committees
- Stellantis holds a contractual board-nomination right alongside its manufacturing partnership and equity — a strategic related-party relationship
- co-founder Brett Adcock departed in 2022; pre-revenue execution is concentrated on the founder-CEO

PEOPLE READ

The headline positive is that the dual-class super-voting sunset to clean one-share-one-vote at the end of 2024, so the founder’s votes now equal his ~5% economics; a majority-independent board with independent committees and a lead independent director backs that up. The offsets are a combined Chair/CEO, a classified/staggered board, and high key-person risk — a pre-revenue, cash-burning certification story concentrated on the founder-CEO after the other co-founder left in 2022.

THE FOUR LEGS

People

observable composite · 1–5

Opportunity

The scenario distribution · the Page-3 business snapshot

Context

The 7 Powers analysis (Power Origination)

Deal

Open-market purchase = the deal: entry price vs. the scenario distribution (the +17.7% finding) + position sizing.



Archer Aviation supporting analysis · disclaimers · glossary

Bear \$0.69 Base \$1.94 Bull \$29.79

PUSHBACK · WHY THE BASE CASE IS TOO HARSH

- 1

Half of Joby's price, similar cert position.
~\$5.4B cap vs Joby's ~\$11B on a near-identical TC stage — the cheaper entry is the whole thesis.
- 2

Defense optionality Joby lacks.
Anduril autonomous-VTOL JV + \$142M USAF AFWERX + EDGE/Omen powertrain — a second revenue leg and a DoD-program-of-record call option.
- 3

Stellantis as contract manufacturer.
Automotive mass-production discipline behind the Covington line; the manufacturing partner is hands-on, not just strategic.
- 4

\$1.78B cash, low debt.
Funds the next phase; the constraint is burn (~\$727M/yr), not insolvency today.
- 5

First to close FAA 'Phase 3'.
Real certification progress; the gap to Joby is conforming-aircraft flight testing, not paperwork.

FALSIFICATION TRIGGERS

Bull validation FAA Type Certificate (2026-27) · Anduril → DoD program of record · UAE/US commercial ops generating revenue · Covington line at rate	Bear validation TC slips beyond 2027 · order book stays LOIs · burn forces dilutive raises < \$5/share	Reframe needed if a major DoD program of record is awarded, the defense leg re-rates independently of UAM — revisit the bull/ultra weights
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GLOSSARY · CONCEPTS REFERENCED IN THE NARRATIVE

Midnight — Archer's 4-passenger + pilot eVTOL, ~100-mile range, 12 tilt-rotors; targets short city hops.	Type Certification (TC) — The FAA's airworthiness approval; no eVTOL has one yet — the gating risk for the whole sector.	Anduril JV — Archer's partnership to build an autonomous hybrid-VTOL for a potential DoD program of record — the defense leg Joby lacks.
Launch Edition — Archer's direct-operations model in international markets (UAE, etc.) ahead of US commercial UAM.	Sales-to-capital (s2c) — Damodaran reinvestment efficiency — incremental revenue per dollar of reinvested capital.	